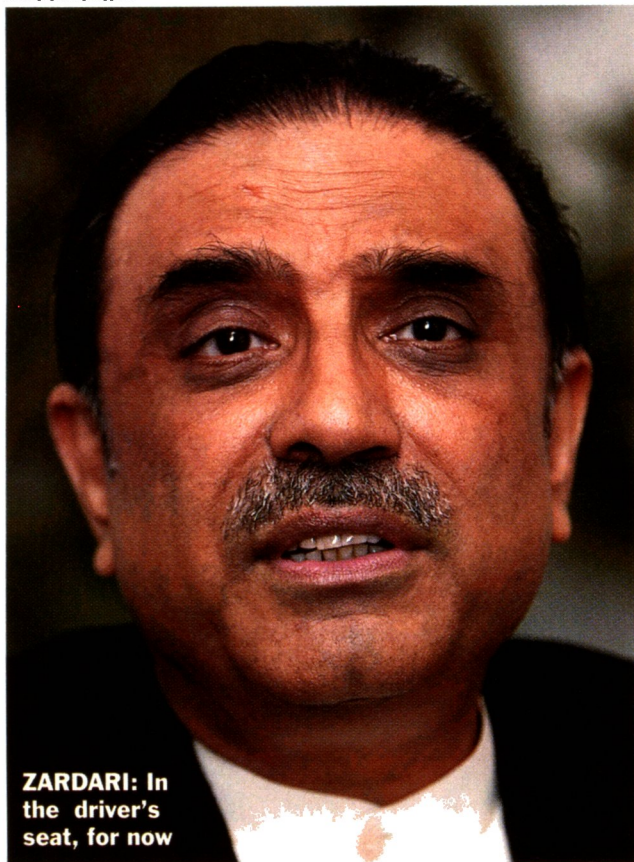


AP PHOTO K M CHAUDARY



ZARDARI: In the driver's seat, for now

AP PHOTO ANJUM NAVEED



SHARIF: Outsmarted but not out

ADVANTAGE ZARDARI

After having Pervez Musharraf ousted, Asif Zardari outmanoeuvres Nawaz Sharif and stakes his claim to the presidency. But with the coalition splitting, the political uncertainty heightens.

■ **By Hasan Zaidi in Karachi**

Even by the standards of Pakistan's fractious politics, the speed with which the ruling coalition unravelled, within a week of its greatest triumph, was breathtaking. On August 18, the coalition partners were rejoicing over having forced the resignation of their main nemesis, former president Pervez Musharraf. On August 25, former prime minister Nawaz Sharif was accusing his ally, Asif Zardari, of deceiving him, and announcing that his party would now sit on the Opposition benches.

For those hoping for some stability in Pakistan with the exit of Musharraf—who had been accused by his opponents of “conspiring against the transition to democracy”—this was

hardly glad tidings. With extremist violence mounting in the wake of a fierce military operation in the northwest of the country and inflation spiralling out of control, political volatility is only likely to deepen the crisis.

Analysts had long questioned the viability of the alliance between Zardari's Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP) and Sharif's Pakistan Muslim League, PML(N), once the glue that united them—their animosity to Musharraf—had gone. Not only are the two parties primary rivals for the top slots in the Government, they are also poles apart as far as ideological underpinnings are concerned. The PPP, all its ideological compromises notwithstanding, is a liberal, left-of-centre party with a rank and file that still draws inspiration from the slogan of socialism espoused by its

founder Zulfikar Ali Bhutto. On the other hand, the PML(N) is a right-of-centre party that draws its support from a more conservative base, reflective of the origins of its leader as a civilian poster-child for Islamist military dictator General Zia-ul-Haq.

But most political pundits were surprised at the fragility of the alliance. On the face of it, Sharif took a “principled” decision, citing Zardari's reneging on written agreements between the two leaders. At his overcrowded press conference announcing his decision to pull out of the Government, Sharif projected on large screens the agreements signed by both leaders, the last of which was inked as late as August 7. In them, Zardari had clearly committed to restoring the judges sacked by Musharraf on November 3 last year